

Tips & Tricks

SECRETS THAT KEEP YOU AHEAD IN THE RACE

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FIREFOX



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A lot of Firefox's behaviour is controlled by typing in "about:config" into the title bar and modifying the values you see there. In the following, we'll be referring extensively to these values. Modifying them is a right-click away. Just open the about:config page once, and you'll get the idea! In the following, when we talk about something like "browser.xxx. xxx", we're talking about that value in the about:config page.



We Don't Like Ads, So...

Before we get into a few Firefox hacks, there are three extensions we think are so essential to your Firefox browsing experience, we can't not mention them. The first of these is Adblock, which is available from <http://adblock.mozdev.org>. Adblock

senses what elements of a page are ads, and can either just hide them or remove them from the page. Browsing was never this fast!

Adblock needs a filter list with words indicative of ads. You could try populating it on your own, and we'd tell you how, but you can...



Have It All Done For You!

We beg you to visit www.pierceve.com. There you'll find Adblock Filterset.G Updater. This little extension synchronises Adblock with Filterset.G—which adds everything to Adblock's filter list that you'd need. It checks for updates, something like an anti-spyware. For example, you'll often see ads getting downloaded from atwola.com; this site is in the list. As more ad servers spring up, and as different tags start getting used for ads, the list gets updated—ensuring you'll almost never see an ad again!



And A Flavour Of Opera...

The third extension you can't live without is SessionSaver. It does just that—you close Firefox with ten tabs open, and the next time you start up Firefox—even after a system restart—all the tabs will open up! No more bookmarking tabs you're about to close! Opera users have had this functionality for a long time. For SessionSaver, visit <https://addons.mozilla.org/firefox/436/>



New Tab: In Front Or Behind?

For those used to tabbed browsing, it does make a difference whether a tab appears in front or opens silently in the background. Even for tabs that open as a

result of an action in another application, such as when you click on a link in Outlook, you can control whether to have them open in the foreground or in the background. Navigate to **browser.tabs.loadDivertedInBackground** in **about:config**. Set it to, of course, True if you want the new tab in the background.



The DNS Cache #1

Network.dnsCacheEntries determines how many entries should be held in the Firefox DNS cache. You might want to select a higher number than the default. The default value for this one varied depending on version. 20 is a value in some versions; it's 256 in some other versions. Change this number to match the number of sites you regularly browse per day—this is intuitive, isn't it? Also check the next setting to ensure DNS entries are kept up to date.



The DNS Cache #2

Network.dnsCacheExpiration determines how long cached DNS entries are held before they are discarded. The default is 60 seconds, which seems too short to us. However, before changing this setting, you need to consider the pros and cons: the longer the cached entries are held, the quicker your browsing will be, but the downside is that it will take longer for Firefox to be aware that a site that was temporarily unavailable is resolved. In any case, like we said, 60 is too low a value.



How The Cache Should Be Used

Don't confuse "cache" here with the DNS cache: this one refers to the caching of pages by Firefox. One of the most important settings in the about:config page is **browser.cache.check_doc_frequency**. Here are the values and their meanings:

0: Check for a new version of a page once per session (a session starts when the first application window opens and ends when the last application window closes).

1: Check for a new version every time a page is loaded.

2: Never check for a new version—always load the page from cache.

3: Check for a new version when the page is out of date.

3 happens to be the default; you can speed up Firefox a little by changing the value to 0. You'd never want 1, and you might want 2 in a few cases. Remember that if you use 2, odd behaviour might occur, mostly when the Back and Forward buttons come into play.



Memory Usage

Under **browser.cache.memory.capacity** is specified how much physical memory (in KB) is allocated to the caching of decoded images and chrome